

open source is gaining momentum, but SMEs have not been targeted yet. Open source will benefit SMEs for multiple reasons: the first is cost—the initial cost for software is negligible, compared to proprietary software. OSS provides free, good-quality technology solutions. And since it is open, users can potentially adapt it to their needs and customise it according to their requirements. Providing support to SMEs in open source is itself an opportunity for a start-up,” Sasikumar said.

However, Vipin Singh, director—EDCS, e-governance department of Karnataka had a different take. “More than open source, SMEs should first start using information technology. IT penetration is very low among SMEs. Open source brings in huge opportunities. It may not solve all the problems. But it is very secure and bugs are removed more frequently than in proprietary software,” he said, delivering the inaugural address. Vinay L. Deshpande, chairman and CEO, Encore Software and Surendra Kumar, chief executive, Precision International also spoke during the event.

The inaugural session was followed by a round-table session on open source. R K V S Raman, senior scientist, CDAC-Bangalore, chaired the session, titled ‘OSS awareness, access, application and acceptability in MSMEs’. Manish Malhotra, director and country-head, software, Sun Microsystems India, Venkat Mangudi, founder and CEO, Venkat Mangudi Consulting, and Arun Mehta, OSS consultant, also spoke at the gathering.

Raman said that open source had several clear advantages. It has no licence fees, and no vendor lock-in; it is almost entirely based on open standards, while being available in various sizes. It has great flexibility for the various needs of a business, and users will get support from small firms or

even larger companies like Red Hat or Novell.

Malhotra pointed out that a product need not be considered an open source product if any one component of it is open. Open source only means that the source is available and code is distributed freely. “The market is shifting to open source, and many companies are using open source for mission-critical applications. Ubuntu is emerging as one of the most popular Linux desktops,” he noted. Vendors can make money by providing subscriptions, support, services, advanced training and so on. “Total cost of ownership, hardware costs, cost of software, licence costs, annual security costs, etc., can be reduced or brought to nil by using open source,” Mangudi pointed out.

“Today, writing software is like walking over a mine due to ‘intellectual property’ issues. As a small company, you also have to protect your own intellectual property. If one is working on OSS, one should not have to worry about ‘intellectual property,’” Mehta said. FOSS has several advantages like inherent UNIX security, direct interaction with developers, cheaper hardware requirements, easy installation and upgrade process, excellent Web facility, and cross-platform support.

This session was followed by a panel discussion on *OSS-Technology: Convenience vs Business Risk*, chaired by Sasikumar. Hemant Verma, deputy director, CII-SME Division, Malhotra, Mehta, Raman and Mangudi participated in the discussion. The panel discussed the challenges of evaluating and adopting IT as well as open source software for business requirements.



By: KTP Radhika

The author is a Linux admirer and correspondent at LFY's Bangalore Bureau.

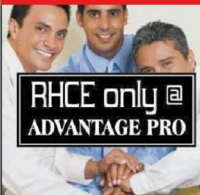


redhat®

TRAINING PARTNER

RHCE / RHCSS Exam Centre

Hundreds of hardcore
Industry Professionals
Vouch for it.



RHCE only @ ADVANTAGE PRO

- Pioneer in LINUX training since 1999.
- Chennai's #1 RHCE training Centre
- 100% results every month.
- Many centum students.
- Also get trained on My SQL - CMDDBA, CMDEV, PHP, Perl, Ruby, Python, Ajax...

**Next RHCE/RHCSS Exam on
13th & 27th April'09**

Don't wait.
Register Now.

Let the success vouch for you!



ADVANTAGE PRO

IT TRAINING DIVISION OF
Vectra Technosoft Pvt. Ltd.
Open Source Academy

Regd. Off: Wing 1 & 2, IV Floor,
Jhaver Plaza, 1A, N.H. Road,
Nungambakkam, Chennai - 34.
Ph : 28263529 / 3530 / 3540
Telefax : 28263527
E-mail : enquiry@vectratech.in
www.vectratech.in